Apex Corruption causes Violent Protests*

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Abstract

We document that *apex* corruption scandals—corrupt acts implicating top-level politicians—cause immediate and persistent increases in violent protests across Latin America. Using a panel of 176 corruption scandals across 23 countries from 2008 to 2018, merged with daily protest counts, we establish three facts: The daily count of violent protests increases by about 59% in the month immediately after the scandal. The effect appears within a week of the scandal, and remains positive even 4 months later. The magnitude of the effect scales sharply with the political rank of the implicated agent: scandals involving sitting presidents show effects 8 times larger than those involving Governors or Supreme Court judges. Our findings identify a high-frequency, high-magnitude channel through which corruption shapes the political environment in democracies.

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1 Introduction

Political violence is among the most consequential outcomes a democracy can experience. Civil unrest disrupts economic activity, displaces investment, and—when met with state violence in return—erodes the social contract that legitimizes the regime. An influencial economic literature has linked political violence to economic shocks (Miguel et al. 2004; McGuirk and Burke 2020), to commodity rents and network structure (König et al. 2017; Dube and Vargas 2013), to the foundations of state capacity (Besley and Persson 2011), and in recent work to abrupt withdrawals of foreign assistance (Rohner et al. 2026). Related work shows that protests themselves can produce durable political effects (Madestam et al. 2013; Bursztyn et al. 2021). The contribution of political shocks to events that change citizens' beliefs about who governs them, however, has received considerably less attention. In this paper we argue that disclosures of apex corruption are one such shock, and that the behavioral consequences for political violence are large, immediate, and persistent.

Corruption has been long studied, with known costs for growth and public goods provision (Mauro 1995; Treisman 2007; Olken 2007; Olken and Pande 2012; Glaeser and Saks 2006). In the past two decades, citizens' perceptions of corruption prevalence have risen (Cantoni et al. 2024), and corruption scandals associated to *apex* politicians have drawn more attention from news outlets in recent years (Rivera et al. 2024); perhaps unsurprisingly due to the expansion of social media, which reduces the cost of diffusing information and enables news outlets to reach broader audiences (Enikolopov et al. 2018; Tufekci 2024; DellaVigna and Kaplan 2007). Even though exposing corruption scandals on news outlets can have positive desired effects, such as political accountability or crackdowns of corruption networks (Ferraz and Finan 2011a; Arias et al. 2019, 2022), it can also have negative undesired effects on democratic values (Ajzenman 2021; Rivera et al. 2024) and away from the polling booths. Public exposure of malfeasance by sitting officials changes what citizens believe about who governs them and about the rules under which the government operates. The most consequential corruption-related political moments of the last decade, such as Brazil's Lava Jato[1], were mobilization events, not electoral ones.

We document that apex corruption—corrupt acts implicating top-level politicians—triggers immediate and persistent increases in violent protests across Latin American democracies. Using a hand-curated panel of 176 corruption scandals across 23 countries from 2008 to 2018, merged with daily protest counts from the Mass Mobilization (MM) project (Clark and Regan 2016), we establish three facts. First, the daily count of violent protests increases by 59% in the month immediately after the scandal, relative to the month immediately preceding the scandal. The count of peaceful protests,

[1] See this video for more information on the scandal.

however, remains largely unaffected. Second, the effect appears within a week of the scandal disclosure, and remains positive even 4 months later, relative to the immediate month before the scandal. Third, the magnitude of the effect scales sharply with the political rank of the implicated agent: scandals involving sitting presidents show effects 8 times larger than those involving Governors or Supreme Court judges. Scandals inolving Congressmen, lower judiciary, and other non-apex officials leave protest patterns broadly unchanged.

2 Method

2.1 Study Design and Measures

Our empirical analyses exploit the randomness of corruption scandal disclosures in Latinamerican news outlets between 2008 and 2018. In particular, we use a stacked difference-in-differences design in which we compare the evolution of protest occurrences in countries with scandals to those without scandals. Our analysis dataset is created by: (i) Scraping the Twitter accounts from news outlets in Latin America to identify the calendar date in which a scandal in a given country is first reported[2], (ii) create an event-window of $T \in \{30, 120\}$ days before and after the scandal, (iii) merge the country-day count of protests from the MM data to create a 'scandal-protest' dataset for a given country in a given calendar-date window, and lastly, (iv) append all such scandal-protest datasets to build the analysis dataset.

The MM dataset is available for the period 1990–2020, and it includes information on the date, size, and location of any episode in which 50 or more protesters publicly demonstrate against the State. If a protest lasts X days, we code the occurrence of a protest at date $t, t+1, \ldots, t+X-1$. If the same protest is associated with more than one date (e.g., because the news source for the protest cannot accurately identify whether it is a continued or a new protest), then we keep the date of the earliest protest. For a protest to be classified as "violent", "[t]he violence could include anything from riotous behavior that destroys property to shooting at the police or military" (Clark and Regan 2016). Our main outcome is the number of protests occurring in a given country-date. We focus on the years 2008–2018, given that our corruption scandals data is available for those years.

We use Ordinary Least Squares (OLS)—and Poisson Quasi-maximum Likelihood Estimation (QML) to account for the count nature of the outcome—to estimate the following equation:

$$Y_{c(s)t} = \beta \ \mathbb{1}\{t \geq \text{Scandal Date}_{c(s)}\} + \alpha_d + \lambda_m + \theta_{cy} + \varepsilon_{c(s)t} \tag{1}$$

[2] We keep the date of the first news report to (a) be able to estimate the effect of a scoop, and (b) avoid double-counting a scandal due to follow-up news reports on it.

where α_d denote day of the week fixed effects, λ_m denote month of the year fixed effects, θ_{cy} denote country-year fixed effects, Scandal $\text{Date}_{c(s)}$ is the date in which corruption scandal s in country c occurs, Y_{ct} denotes the outcome of interest in country c at date t, and $\varepsilon_{c(s)t}$ is an idiosyncratic error term.

To trace dynamics we replace $\mathbb{1}\{t \geq \text{Scandal Date}_{c(s)}\}$ in Equation 1 with a saturated set of 30-day bin indicators for four months before/after the scandal. The reference category in each time-to-event graph is the bin immediately before disclosure (i.e., $w_{s,t} \in [-30, -1]$).

The identification assumption we rely on for our estimates to be interpreted as causal is that conditional on country-year, month-of-year, and day-of-week fixed effects, the within-year date of disclosure of a scandal is as-good-as-randomly assigned in relation to the protest baseline of the country. The country-year fixed effects absorb every source of country-year-level confounding such as pre-existing political instability, electoral calendars, or institutional reforms. The day-of-week and month-of-year fixed effects absorb weekly and seasonal cycles in protest activity.

3 Results

3.1 Apex corruption increases violent protests

Table 1 reports our OLS (Panel A) and Poisson (Panel B) estimates of the effect of apex corruption on violent and peaceful protests in 30- and 120-day windows. In our OLS specification, we estimate an increase of 0.016 violent protests per country-day in both the one and four months windows ($P < 0.01$ and $P = 0.012$, respectively), roughly 59% of the pre-scandal mean in the week before the scandal. Peaceful protests do not show statistically nor economically significant effects. In the 30-day window, we estimate an increase of 0.01 protests per country-day ($P = 0.219$, 14% of the pre-scandal-bin mean), and a 0.009 *decrease* in the 120-day window ($P = 0.212$, 17% of the pre-scandal-bin mean). The Poisson QML estimates—which account for the count nature of the outcome—imply large proportional effects: violent protests rise by 54% in the 30-day window ($P < 0.001$) and by 63% in the 120-day window ($P = 0.047$). Peaceful protests, on the other hand, show effects in opposing directions on the two time windows: they increase by 25% in the 30-day window following the scandal ($P = 0.095$), and they *decrease* by 21% in the 120-day window after the scandal disclosure ($P = 0.049$). The opposite-signed response in peaceful protests across windows is consistent with a substitution from peaceful to violent mobilization on the longer horizon, though our design does not allow us to identify substitution directly.

Table 1. Violent protests increase after apex corruption scandal disclosures.

	±30-Day Window		±120-Day Window	
	(1) Violent Protests	(2) Peaceful Protests	(3) Violent Protests	(4) Peaceful Protests
Panel A: OLS				
Post Scandal	0.016***	0.010	0.016**	-0.009
	(0.005)	(0.008)	(0.006)	(0.007)
Mean (Pre-Scandal Bin)	0.027	0.069	0.020	0.053
Observations	10736	10736	42657	42657
Number of Scandals	176	176	176	176
R-squared	0.160	0.473	0.126	0.300
Panel B: Poisson QML				
Post Scandal	0.433***	0.227*	0.490**	-0.240*
	(0.097)	(0.122)	(0.195)	(0.138)
Implied Prop. Effect	0.542***	0.254*	0.632**	-0.213**
	(0.149)	(0.152)	(0.318)	(0.108)
Mean (Pre-Scandal Bin)	0.072	0.114	0.039	0.067
Observations	3996	6454	21585	33529
Number of Scandals	74	108	98	149
Pseudo R-squared	0.317	0.424	0.259	0.295
Country × Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
SE Cluster	C × Y × DB	C × Y × DB	C × Y × DB	C × Y × DB

The table reports OLS estimates (Panel A) and Poisson QML estimates (Panel B) of β from Equation 1 for four outcome–window combinations: violent and peaceful protests, each estimated on the ±30-day window (columns 1–2) and on the ±120-day window (columns 3–4) around each scandal's public-disclosure date. An observation is a country-day inside the event window of a scandal; the 176 apex corruption scandals across 23 Latin American countries are stacked. All specifications include country-by-year, month-of-year, and day-of-week fixed effects. Standard errors (in parentheses) are clustered at the country × year × day-bin level. In Panel B, the Poisson QML coefficient is on the log scale; "Implied Prop. Effect" reports the implied proportional effect $\exp(\beta) - 1$, with the delta-method standard error in parentheses below. "Mean (Pre-Scandal Bin)" is the average value of the outcome in the bin immediately before the scandal's disclosure—a 6-day bin in columns (1)–(2) and a 30-day bin in columns (3)–(4)—computed over the corresponding regression sample. The Poisson sample is smaller than the OLS sample because `ppmlhdfe` drops observations that are either singletons or separated by a fixed effect. The sample period is 2008–2018; Venezuela is excluded. Significance: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

3.2 Protest dynamics around apex corruption scandals

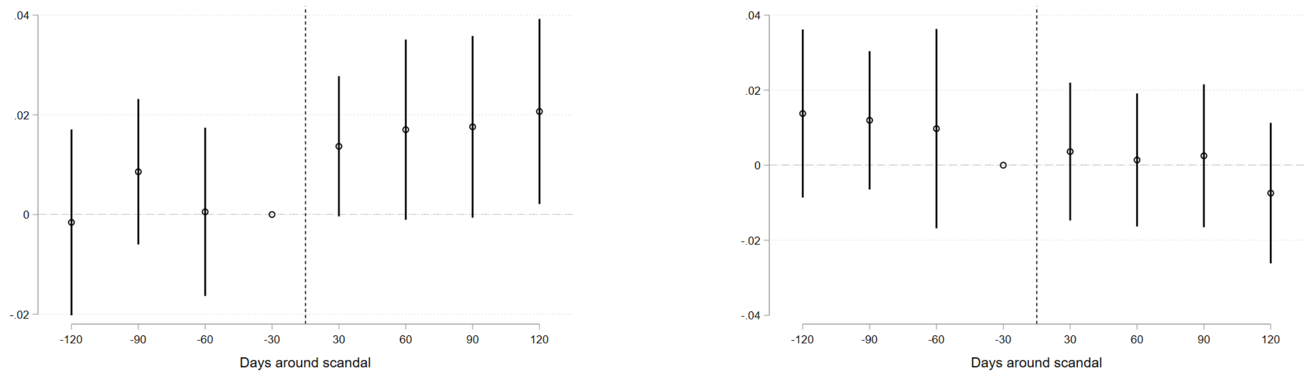
In Figure 1 we show OLS estimates of the dynamics of the effects of apex corruption scandals using our modified Equation 1, in which we substitute the indicator for post-scandal dates with a fully saturated set of indicators for 30-day bins of dates (in the 120-day window) within the scandal date.

Violent protests (Figure 1a) show no trend prior to the scandal disclosures, and then suddenly increase by 0.014 protests per country-day in the first 30-days after the scandal disclosure, relative to the 30-days before the scandal disclosure ($P = 0.110$). The point estimates remain positive and similar in magnitude in the three months that follow. Peaceful protests (Figure 1b) follow a different trajectory. Prior to the scandal there is no statistically significant trend, and they do not exhibit changes after scandal disclosure, with point estimates ranging from -0.007 to 0.004 ($P = 0.513$ and $P = 0.745$, respectively). These results suggest that violent protests are the durable component of citizen mobilization following apex corruption scandals.

Figure 1. Violent protests increase and peaceful protests decrease in the 120-days after a scandal disclosure.

(a) Violent Protests
± 120-day window (30-day bins).

(b) Peaceful Protests
± 120-day window (30-day bins).



This figure shows the estimates on event-time bin indicators from the modified version of Equation 1 described in Section 2. The omitted reference bin is the one for 1-6 days before the scandal in Panels (a) and (c), and for 1-30 days before the scandal in Panels (b) and (d). Vertical bars are 90% confidence intervals. An observation is a country-scandal-date.

3.3 Heterogeneity by political rank

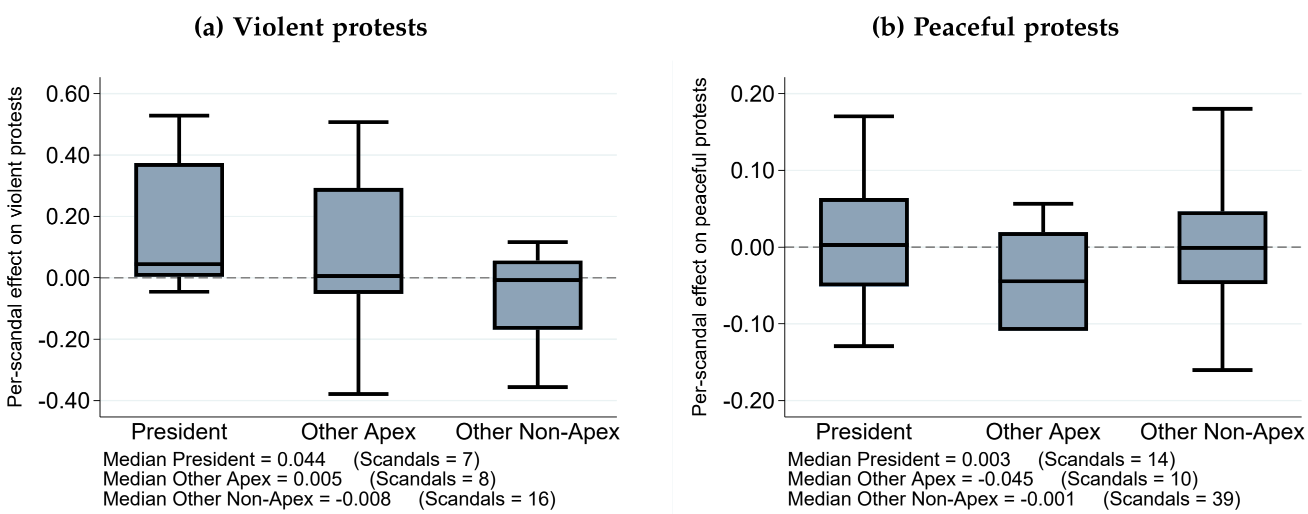
We have thus far showed that apex corruption scandals cause protests to turn violent, and that the effects persist even four months after a scandal is disclosed. In this section we show that the effects are heterogeneous even within the apex of the political spectrum. To do this, we classify each of our scandals according to the position of the implicated politician. Then, we estimate Equation 1 for each of our scandals individually on its own country's 30-day window (i.e., the scandal-protest datasets described in step (ii) in Section 2), and plot the distribution of point estimates for each of the categories of implicated politicians. Our sample has 45 scandals in which the implicated politician is a president, and within the remaining 131 scandals, 19 implicate Governors and Supreme Court Judges (we call this group "Other Apex"), and 112 implicate Congressmen, lower judiciary, and other lower level officials ("Other Non-apex"). Since some of the scandals show no variation in the outcome, the boxplots show the distribution of effects in the subsample of country-years in which mobilization happens[3].

Figure 2 characterizes the heterogeneity of the protest response across the political rank of the

[3]Our dataset may suffer from underreporting if, e.g., protests happen but less than 50 people take part in them. Under this scenario, the MM dataset would not code a protest occurrence.

implicated official. For violent protests, the median effect size is of 0.044 protests per country-day, which is about 8 times larger than the median effect for scandals implicating Governors and Supreme Court Judges. Peaceful protests on the other hand show little to no difference in the median effects. The median effect for scandals implicating Presidents is 0.003, while the median effect for scandals implicating Governors or Supreme Court Judges is a 0.045 *decrease*. Scandals implicating Congressmen, lower judiciary, and lower rank officials have median effects of -0.008 and -0.001 on violent and peaceful protests. These results highlight the importance of the "apexness" component of the scandals. Even though corruption in general may be condemned by citizens, it is apex corruption that generates violent mobilization. A potential explanation for our findings is that mobilization rises with the stakes of the scandal: scandals implicating lower level officials are detrimental to democracy but may not warrant violent mobilization as they are potentially less able to affect society at a large scale. Higher level officials—Presidents in particular—, can generate large scale costs to society when engaging in corrupt behavior.

Figure 2. Scandals implicating Presidents cause larger increases in violent protests.



We estimate the OLS post-scandal coefficient of Equation 1 on the ±30-day window of the implicated country alone, retaining the day-of-week and month-of-year fixed effects. Each panel summarizes, by box plot, the cross-scandal distribution of those per-scandal coefficients $\hat{\beta}_s$ for the corresponding outcome under the apex partition: President (45 scandals), Other Apex (19 scandals; Governors and Supreme-Court Justices), and Other Non-Apex (112 scandals; members of Congress, lower judiciary, and lower officials). The note inside each panel reports the within-category median of $\hat{\beta}_s$ and the number of scandals contributing to each category. For some scandals the outcome has no within-window variation—i.e., the implicated country recorded no protests of the relevant type throughout the ±30-day window—in which case the per-scandal regression cannot identify an effect and the scandal is dropped from the corresponding box plot. The sample period is 2008–2018; Venezuela is excluded.

4 Discussion

The evidence we have presented suggests citizens do not respond uniformly to all types of corruption: they respond sharply, immediately and durably when the implicated official is at the apex of the political spectrum, and they barely respond when the implicated official sits at the lower tier of the hierarchy. Furthermore, the response concentrates on violent protests and persists even after four months. The peaceful margin, which relies more on institutional punishment and change, atenuates over the four month horizon (and even reverses sign in our Poisson estimates.). Our findings undermine the fact that corruption is a tangible behavioral shock to the local (and perhaps even regional) political environment, not just an attitudinal one. The stakes citizens hold in the continuation in office of a corrupt official govern whether citizens mobilize, and how they do so. And lastly, when citizens lose confidence in institutional channels of accountability, mobilization switches from peaceful to violent.

Our findings contribute to three literatures. First, the economics-of-conflict literature has documented that political violence responds to economic shocks (König et al. 2017; McGuirk and Burke 2020; Dube and Vargas 2013; Besley and Persson 2011; Berman et al. 2011; Rohner et al. 2026). We introduce a *political* shock—public disclosure of apex corruption—and show that it produces mobilization responses of comparable magnitude to the ones caused by economic shocks. Second, the corruption and accountability literature has documented that disclosures of malfeasance change voting behavior (Ferraz and Finan 2008, 2011a,b; Avis et al. 2018; Arias et al. 2019). The slow electoral horizon has tended to obscure that the same disclosures can have very fast, non-electoral consequences (Madestam et al. 2013; Bursztyn et al. 2021). Our high-frequency design uncovers a channel through which apex corruption shapes the political environment in democracies within days of public disclosures, well before subsequent elections come into play. Third, the protest channel is the behavioral complement of the attitudinal evidence from our companion paper (Rivera et al. 2024), which documents that apex corruption scandals erode support for democracy and democratic institutions, and also reduce political participation.

Our results help reconcile part of the mixed results in the existing literature on the political consequences of corruption disclosures. Studies of local level corruption have produced muted estimates of disclosure's electoral consequences, with some finding modest accountability gains in Brazil and Spain (Ferraz and Finan 2008, 2011a; Avis et al. 2018; Costas-Pérez et al. 2012) and others finding null or even demobilizing effects (Chong et al. 2015; Anduiza et al. 2013; Pavão 2018; Arias et al. 2022). We argue that the dispersion in municipal estimates reflects the limited political stakes at that level. In particular, when the implicated official is one of many municipal officeholders, citizens have weaker incentives to incur the costs of mobilization. Within our sample, scandals implicating

Congressmen, lower judiciary and lower rank officials, have median per-scandal effects statistically indistinguishable from zero. Scandals implicating Presidents, on the other hand, have median effects roughly 8 times larger than those implicating Governors and Supreme Court Judges. This is consistent with evidence from Latin American presidential approval data that shows that scandals against sitting Presidents are the political margin at which corruption scandals have the largest immediate cost (Carlin et al. 2015).

A "salience of stakeholders" view rationalizes this (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006, 2012; Jha 2013; Jha and Shayo 2019; Jha 2022). Citizens' political behavior responds to the political weight of *what* is being disclosed. Apex corruption, thus, affects citizens' perceived stakes of the political bargain, particularly when the implicated official is at the apex of the political hierarchy. The contrast between high–stakes presidential scandals and low-stakes lower officials scandals parallels the contrast between high-stakes elections and routine governance in studies of political accountability (Martinez-Bravo et al. 2022), and is consistent with the idea that citizen engagement depends on whether institutions can deliver outcomes (Acemoglu et al. 2019, 2024; Depetris-Chauvin et al. 2020).

Our empirical analyses have some limitations worth noting. Our identification strategy relies on the timing of apex corruption disclosures, not on the timing of the corrupt act itself. If the timing of disclosures is correlated with pre-existing political conditions that affect mobilization (violent or peaceful), our estimates could then be biased. Somewhat reassuringly, the pre-scandal estimates in Figure 1 show no evidence of pre-existing trends in mobilization. A second limitation comes from the fact that the MM dataset is constructed by looking at news soruces reporting on mobilization events. Small protests may thus be underreported as they are not big enough to draw media attention, or protests ocurring in geographically remote areas may also be left out. This would induce measurement error in our estimates, but if anything this would bias our estimates toward zero. Relatedly, there is no variation in the outcome around a large share of our scandals, which limits our heterogeneity analysis to the subsample of scandals around which mobilization patterns change. And finally, our scandal sample is limited to Latin American democracies in the 2008–2018 period, which limits the external validity of our findings insofar as different regions in the world may mobilize differently in response to corruption scandals. One could also expect different results when shortening/expanding the time scope of the analysis if one believes that the cumulative amount of apex corruption episodes affect the extent to which citizens mobilize.

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